

SAMANTHA CERVANTES

Maxwell School of Citizenship and Public Affairs, Syracuse University
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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Administration 2022 – 2027 (expected)
Syracuse University, Maxwell School
Fields: Education Policy and Urban Economics
Advisors: Amy E. Schwartz and Michah W. Rothbart

M.S., Applied Economics with Honors 2022
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

Certificate in Applied Statistics 2018 – 2019
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

B.A., Business Administration, minor in Political Science 2018
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Urban Policy, Education Policy, Neighborhood Effects, Economics of Crime

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

The Impacts of High-Intensity Streetlights on Academic Outcomes: Evidence from a Crime Deterrence Experiment

with Amy E. Schwartz

Governments increasingly deploy place-based interventions to reduce crime, but their consequences for the residents who live with them, including children, are rarely evaluated beyond crime itself. In 2016, the New York Police Department randomly assigned high-intensity streetlights – each emitting 600,000 lumens, an extraordinary brightness – to high-crime public housing developments. Linking the experiment to administrative records of New York City public school students, we find that the intervention improved achievement for most exposed students but harmed those living within vertical reach of the lights. Within high-dose developments, students in high-rise (taller) buildings gained 0.11 standard deviations in math and 0.10 in reading, while students in low-rise (shorter) buildings, closer to the street-level lights, lost 0.22 in math. Because these opposing effects offset, the average effect on achievement is near zero, even as the intervention substantially reduced student exposure to nighttime and daytime crime, arrests, and incidents involving underage victims and suspects. Students living just outside high-dose developments, who face little direct light exposure show no height gradient, further suggesting that proximity to the lights drives the losses. These losses are not mirrored by height differences in crime exposure and follow patterns consistent with sleep disruption, concentrating among girls at pubertal ages and in math rather than reading. Part of the harm operated through school disruption: low-rise students became more likely to change schools, and the schools they moved to were of lower quality. The results show that the consequences of place-based safety interventions depend not only on whether they reduce crime, but also on their intensity and on how the built

environment distributes the children who live nearby.

Working Papers

Hold Harmless for Whom? The Impact of COVID Era Policies for School Funding, Teachers, and Students.

with Michah W. Rothbart and Amy E. Schwartz (**R&R at *Education Finance and Policy***)

How a Good School in the Neighborhood Affects Academic Outcomes

with Sarah Cordes, Jeehee Han, Amy E. Schwartz, & **Cervantes, S.**

Works in Progress

The Long-Term Impact of Neighborhood Violence on Youth Outcomes

with Amy E. Schwartz

The Impact of a Crime Deterrence Intervention on Political Behavior

with Ying Shi

Housing Market Responses to Salient Police Interventions: Experimental Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights

with Alexander Cardazzi

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate, Center for Policy Research

2022 –

Professors Michah W. Rothbart and Amy E. Schwartz

Research Assistant, Center for Competitiveness Studies

2019 – 2022

Professor Guillermo Abdel Musik, ITAM

Investment Consultant, Profuturo Pensiones

2018 – 2019

TEACHING

Syracuse University (Graduate-level)

Quantitative Analysis

Spring 2024, Spring 2025

Public Budgeting

Fall 2022, Summer 2023,
Summer 2024

Guest Lecturer: Education Policy, Quantitative Analysis

Spring 2025

PRESENTATIONS

Upcoming: Urban Economics Association (UEA); NYU Furman Center; Southern Economics Association (SEA);

2026: American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association (AREUEA); FLX Economics of Education Workshop; Capital District Applied Microeconomics Workshop; Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)

2025: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

2024: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM); Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP); Public Finance and Budgeting Northeastern Workshop

2023: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

GRANTS & AWARDS

First Place, Graduate Student Poster Session Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University	2026
Summer Dissertation Fellowship Syracuse University	
Ph.D. Department Research Grant Syracuse University	2025
Financial Inclusion Essay Award National Banking and Securities Commission	2021

SERVICE

Graduate Student Representative Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University	2026 – 2027
Ad Hoc Referee: <i>Educational Researcher, Journal of Behavioral Public Administration</i>	

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Statistical software: Stata, R, QGIS, Python